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CyberSecurity

2 - “Overview: Main Concepts and Terminology” *[Chapter 1]*

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Outline



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- Computer Security **Concepts**
- **Threats, Attacks, and Assets**
- Fundamental Security **Design Principles**
- **Attack Surfaces** and **Attack Trees**
- Computer Security **Strategy**

Fundamental Questions



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This slide refers to the central concept and starting point of all computer security and, specifically, describes the fundamental process of threat modeling and risk management.

The focus is on three **fundamental questions**:

It helps you identify your assets (that is, everything of value to the organization (data, servers, software, hardware)), whose loss or damage would result in financial or operational harm. If you don't know exactly what you own and how much it's worth, you risk spending money to protect things that aren't important or, worse, leaving your most critical data completely unprotected.

what assets do we need to **protect**?

It forces you to conduct a threat analysis by putting yourself in the shoes of a potential attacker. This means understanding who your adversary is, what vulnerabilities your system has, and what types of attacks it might face (e.g., malware, credential theft, DDoS attacks). Understanding threats helps you assess the impact and likelihood of an attack. It allows you to quantify the actual risk.

how are those assets **threatened**?

It is used to design solutions and countermeasures to prevent, detect, or mitigate an attack. Since 100% security (zero risk) doesn't exist, the goal isn't to eliminate every threat, but to reduce risk to an acceptable level by managing available resources as intelligently as possible. Protecting everything equally would be impossible and incredibly expensive.

what can we do to **counter those threats**?

Threat Model

You cannot conduct proper risk management without first creating a threat model, and vice versa, a threat model would remain a useless theoretical exercise if risk management did not quantify those risks to determine where to allocate the company's budget.



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- In cybersecurity, a **threat model** is a ^{process} **structured way** of **identifying potential threats, vulnerabilities, and risks** to a system, application, or organization. It is a **systematic approach to understanding the possible attack vectors, threat actors, and the potential impact of successful attacks.** (definition provided by “claude.ai”, 04/03/2024)

Computer Security (NIST definition)



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This computer security definition says that it is impossible to have security if we are not able to guarantee the security baseline: CIA Triad (for some system is enough, for others we need to extend the security properties)

Computer security is

provided to

«The protection afforded to an automated information system in order

achieve

established in terms

to ~~attain~~ the applicable objectives of preserving the **integrity**,

availability and **confidentiality** of information system resources.»

Protection is not limited to “data” alone, but extends to all the assets of the system

It includes hardware, software, firmware, information/data, and

telecommunications

Professor Methodology: From Awareness to Solutions

- 1. Awareness (Consapevolezza): The “zero-risk” scenario does not exist in cybersecurity. Understanding the current threat landscape, identifying potential Threat Actors, and assessing the strategic value of company assets. Recognition of the need for security as an active, ongoing process.
- 2. Problem Definition: Every system is different (e.g., banking infrastructures require different properties than medical IoT devices). To define the problem, you must explicitly define the security properties that need to be guaranteed. Executing custom Threat Modeling and Risk Assessment based on the specific architecture.
- 3. Solutions must never be generic; they are engineered exclusively to solve the problem defined in the previous step. Implementing a multi-layered mitigation strategy

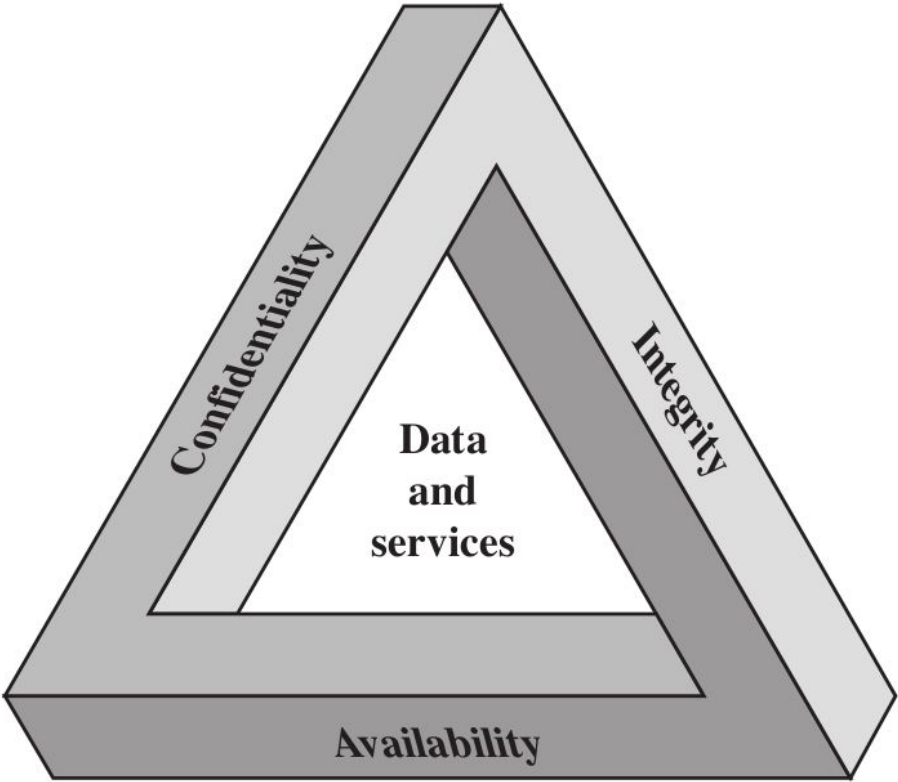
They are referred to as “Requirements” because they establish the mandatory objectives that must be met in order for a system to be officially defined as “secure”. As established by standard definitions (such as that of NIST), cybersecurity consists precisely of the protection provided to a system in order to preserve these three specific properties of the organization’s assets. They represent the baseline, the starting point: if you do not define which of these requirements you must ensure and to what level, you cannot design any cybersecurity countermeasures.



The Security Requirements “CIA” Triad



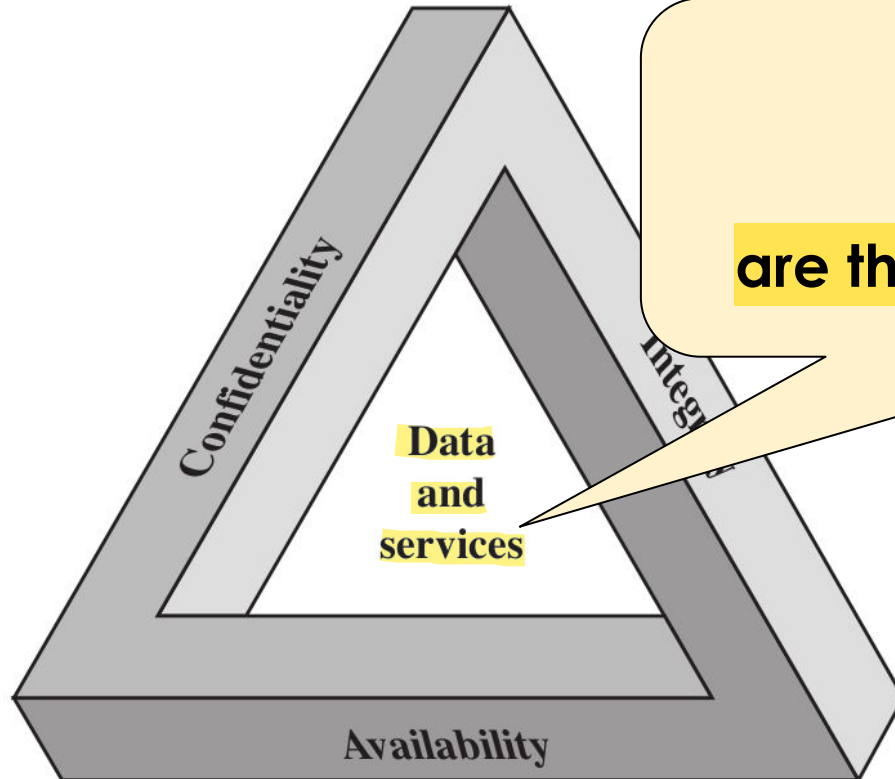
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The Security Requirements “CIA” Triad



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In this approach

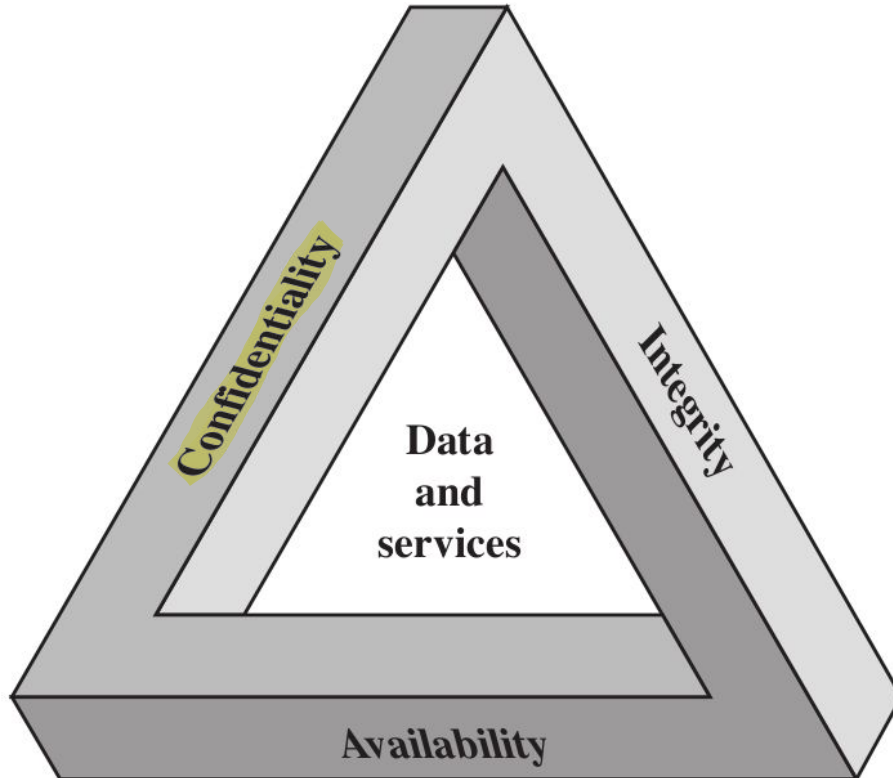
“data and services”

are the core elements to protect

The Security Requirements “CIA” Triad



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confidentiality divided in two different things:

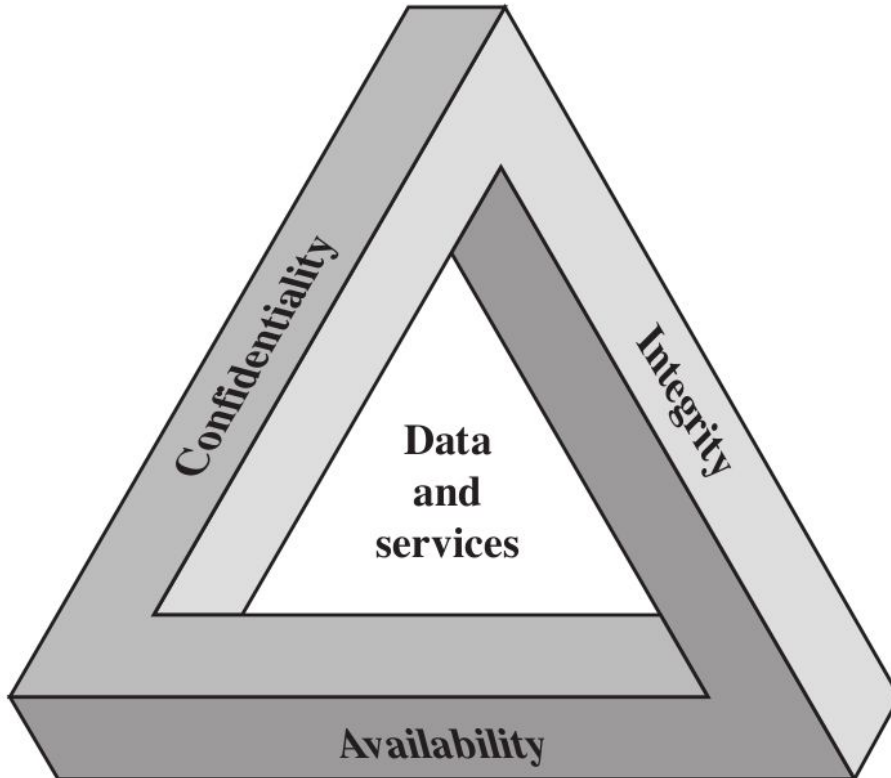
→ **data confidentiality**

→ **privacy** (small subset of Cybersecurity)

The Security Requirements “CIA” Triad



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confidentiality

- data confidentiality
- privacy

example: logs of my activity on Unibo WiFi must be private

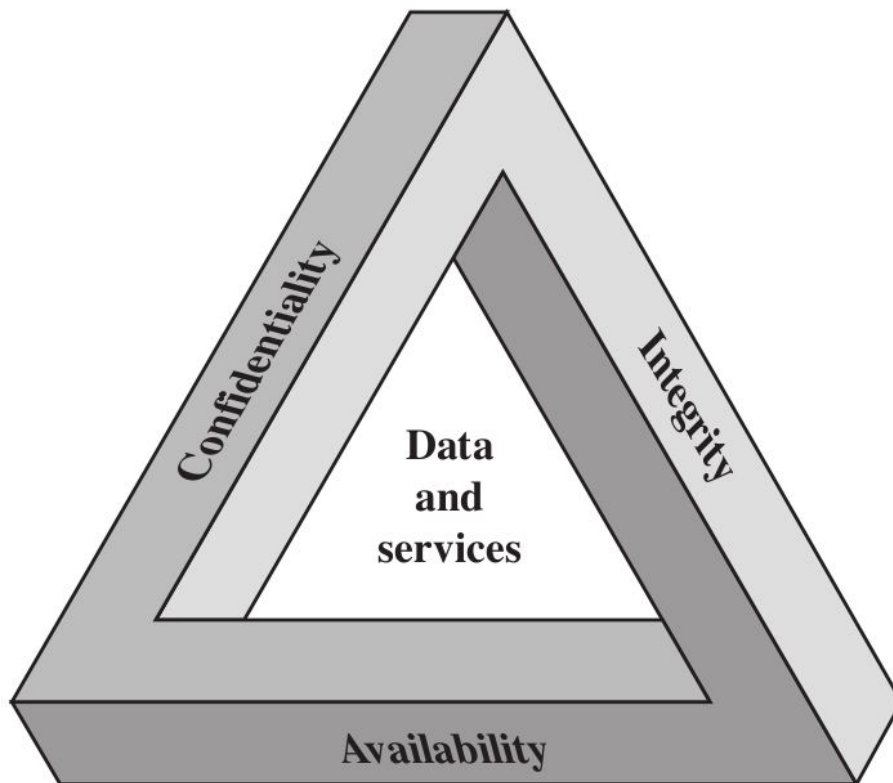
data confidentiality

private or **confidential**
information is not made
available or disclosed
to unauthorized individuals

The Security Requirements “CIA” Triad



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confidentiality

- data confidentiality
- privacy

example: I can
control the level of
visibility of my
pictures on Instagram

privacy

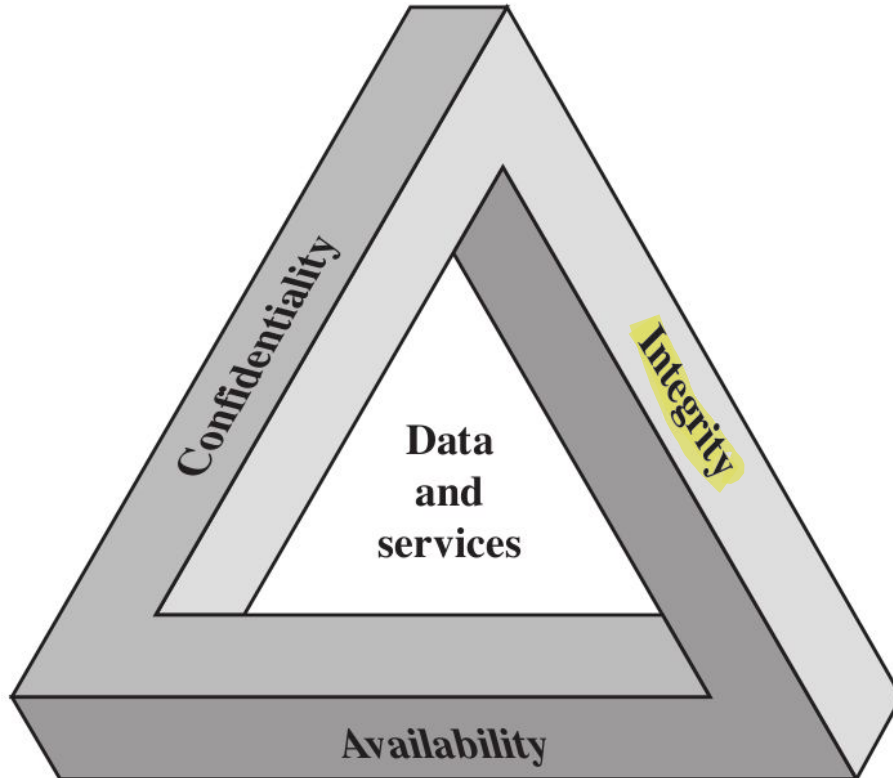
For some data can
be done, for other is
difficult to be done
or not be done

individuals control¹ what
information related to them
may be collected and stored,
² by whom and ³ to whom this
information may be disclosed

The Security Requirements “CIA” Triad



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confidentiality

- data confidentiality
- privacy

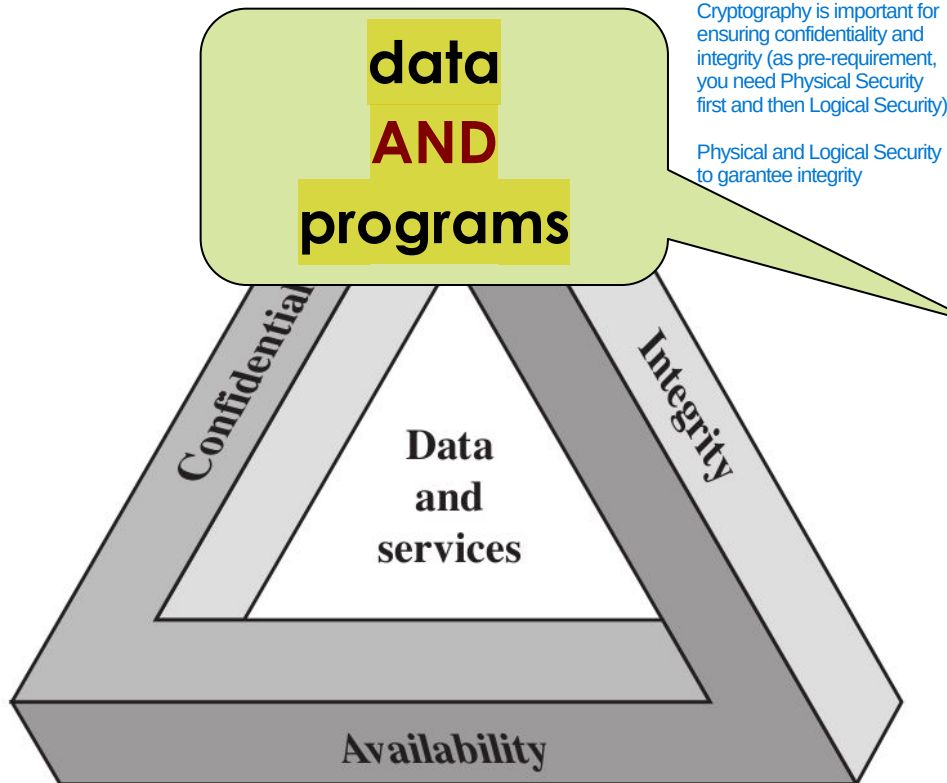
integrity

- data integrity
- system integrity

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confidentiality

- data confidentiality
- privacy

integrity

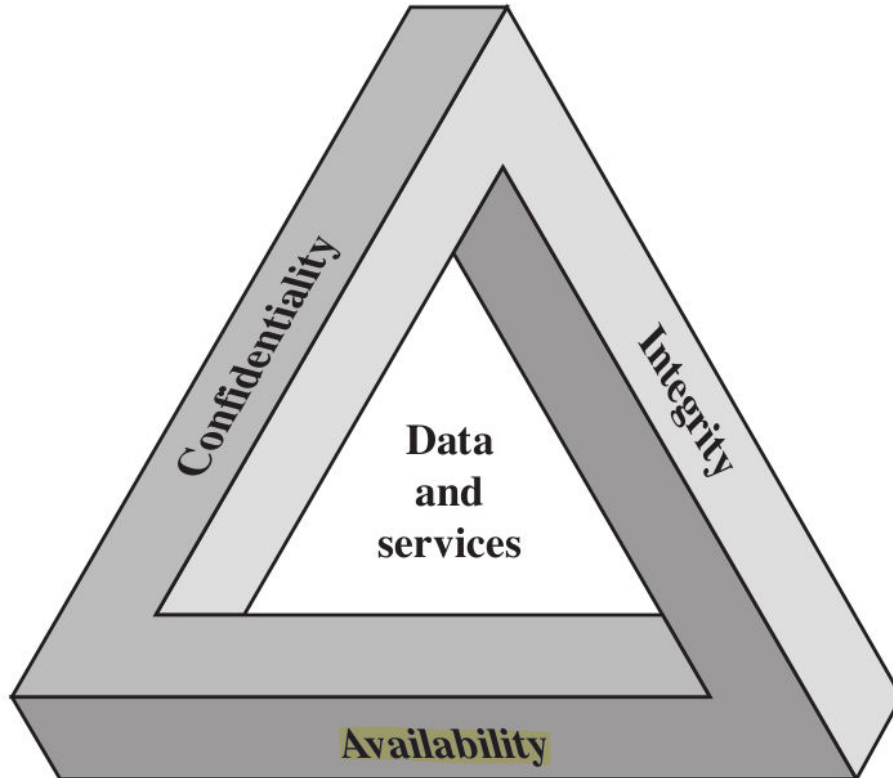
No unauthorized modification are done

- data integrity
- system integrity

The Security Requirements “CIA” Triad



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confidentiality

- data confidentiality
- privacy

integrity

- data integrity
- system integrity

availability

If there isn't, there is no security: if not available, customer cannot visualize its data

- data availability
- services availability

Key Security Concepts



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Confidentiality

Integrity

Availability

The CIA triad represents the three fundamental pillars, that is, the basic security requirements, upon which the entire field of cybersecurity is based. Any security strategy aims to protect these properties as they apply to system data and services.

Key Security Concepts



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Confidentiality

Integrity

Availability

- Preserving authorized restrictions on **information access** and **disclosure**
- Including ^{measures} ~~means~~ for protecting personal **privacy** and proprietary information

Key Security Concepts



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Confidentiality

Integrity

Availability

- Guarding against ^{unauthorized} ~~improper~~ **information modification or destruction** (example: ransomware to attack the integrity of a system)
- Including ensuring **information non-repudiation** and **authenticity** (Non-repudiation is the legal and technical assurance that a particular person cannot deny having performed a specific action.)
(Authenticity is the guarantee that a message, transaction, or data actually comes from the source it claims to be from.)

Key Security Concepts



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Confidentiality

Integrity

Availability

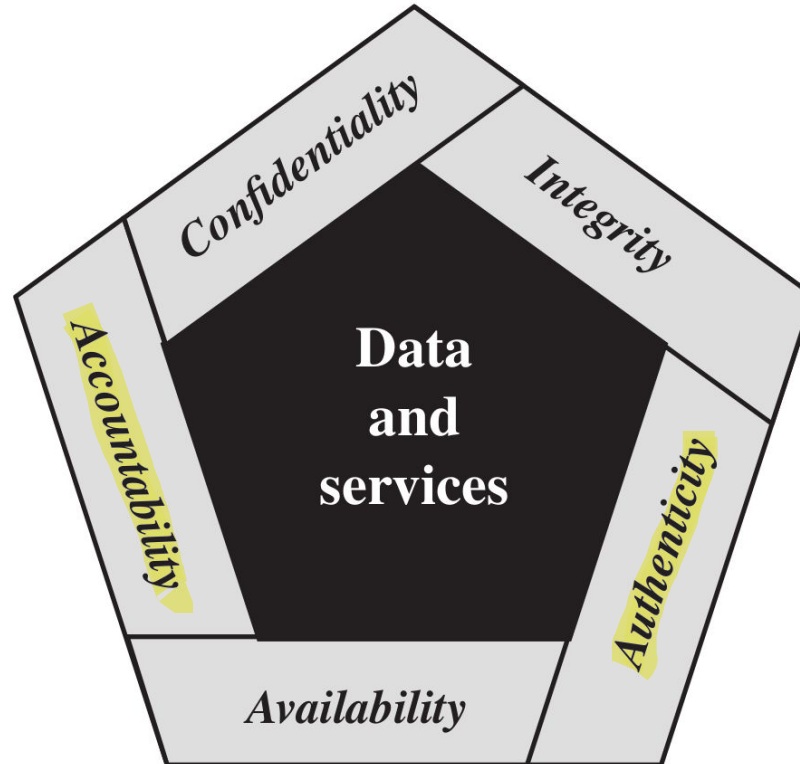
- Ensuring **timely** and **reliable access** to ~~and~~ ~~use of~~ **data** (and **services**)

The Security Requirements



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The CIA Triad and its extension, the Pentagon of Security, are used as conceptual models and reference frameworks for defining the fundamental objectives of any cybersecurity strategy. In simple terms: they are used to answer the question your professor asks during the Problem Definition phase: "What does it actually mean for this specific system to be secure?" You cannot protect a system unless you first define which properties you want to ensure.



Every single system has different requirements: in some cases Triad is enough, in other cases the Triad isn't enough and the Pentagon is enough, in other cases Pentagon isn't enough and we need something else.

Complexity of the system is higher in Pentagon Requirements, than in Triad

Key Security Concepts



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Authenticity

1. Being Genuine: the entity we are analyzing (a user, a message, a network packet, or a piece of software) is exactly what it claims to be, without any alterations or falsifications.
2. Being Able to be Verified: simply saying that a system is “genuine” is not enough; cybersecurity requires mathematical or technical proof. The system must have mechanisms capable of objectively demonstrating and verifying that authenticity.
3. Being Trusted (The “Result”): This is the logical consequence of the first two points. If an entity is genuine and passes the verification process, the system can finally grant it trust. Only at this point, the system allows you to log in, read data, or execute commands because it “trusts” that you are who you say you are.

Accountability

The system does not merely verify who logs in (that is Authenticity), but must record everything the user does from the moment they log in until they log out. Every file opened, every record modified in the database, and every command sent to the server must leave an unmodifiable digital footprint. The primary technical tool for meeting this requirement is activity logs.

This is the most critical and important aspect: uniqueness. There must be no doubt or ambiguity. An action must be linked to a single entity (a specific user, a specific software process, or a specific piece of hardware). What violates this requirement? The use of shared accounts. If, in a company, all system administrators use the shared “admin” account, and someone accidentally deletes a database, the action is logged, but not uniquely. We will never know which individual committed the act. Accountability has failed in this case.

Key Security Concepts



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Authenticity

- Property of being **genuine** and being able to be **verified** and **trusted**
- For example: confidence in the validity of a **transmission**, a **message**, or a message **originator**

Accountability

Key Security Concepts



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Authenticity

Being able to guarantee the Accountability is incredibly hard, but it depends on your setup (company, internet, etc..)

Accountability is possible within organizations or companies, but privacy is reduced. It is difficult to ensure accountability on the Internet due to anonymity, decentralization, and legal issues

Accountability is a Trade-off with Privacy: Accountability often conflicts with privacy, creating a trade-off where increasing transparency for control reduces individual anonymity

Accountability

- The requirement for **actions of an entity** to be **traced uniquely to that entity**
- For example: ability to find the originator of a transmission, a message, or an action

Key Security Concepts

If a company suffers financial loss or a serious breach, it may want to pursue legal action against those responsible (whether they are external hackers or disloyal employees). To go to court, you need evidence. If system logs have been collected and stored securely, in an unmodifiable manner, and in compliance with regulations, they serve as digital forensic evidence, allowing lawyers to take legal action backed by objective facts.



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Authenticity

Without Accountability is not possible to trace in which part of the system the fault has originated

if a malicious employee or system administrator knows that the infrastructure logs every single action they take, they will be strongly discouraged from engaging in unlawful activities. They know they would be caught immediately.

Accountability

The requirement for **actions of an entity** to be **traced uniquely to that entity**

For example: *ability to find the originator of a **transmission**, a **message**, or an action*

I need Accountability

Necessary to support

non-repudiation, deterrence,

fault isolation, intrusion

detection and prevention...

recovery and legal action

I monitor the system, I check what happens. If something that is anomalous is happening on the system, I stop immediately what happens

Important to have in case of Failure of system protection (System compromised in real world, it happens). We can do Intrusion Detection and Prevention if we have Accountability

If things go wrong, you need to be able to decide what has been compromised and what not, and restore the things that has been compromised and maintain everything that has not been compromised



Qualitative classification of Impact

Level of Impact

A security breach of a system, caused by a successful attack, can have 3 different levels of impact:

1

Low

of a specific security property
The loss could be
expected to have a
negative
limited adverse
effect on
organizational
operations,
organizational
assets, or individuals

2

Moderate

The loss could be
expected to have a
negative
serious adverse
effect on
organizational
operations,
organizational
assets, or individuals

3

High

The loss could be
expected to have a
severe or
catastrophic
negative
adverse effect on
organizational
operations,
organizational
assets, or individuals

A common challenge for cybersecurity specialists is asking the CEO for additional funding to enhance system security

Computer Security Challenges



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1 • Computer security is **not as simple as it might first appear to the**

novice

(For each potential attack, you must be able to assess the probability of that attack happening and, for each one, you must be able to determine the level of impact that specific attack will have once it is carried out)

2 • You need to design your defenses with the understanding that they will be the attacker's target.
Potential attacks on the ^{system} security features must be considered

(Example: HTTPS on the internet. The original goal of the internet was maximum efficiency, speed, and ease of connection. Security completely changes this initial goal, on which the internet's design was based, by introducing various steps that might seem like pure madness and a waste of resources.)

3 • Procedures, used to provide particular ^{security} services, are **often**

counterintuitive

↔ The procedures used to ensure security in legacy systems are often counterintuitive, as they require adapting security measures to technologies designed before modern threats existed. As systems evolve over time, understanding how different components enable specific functionalities makes it difficult to ensure their security, often leading to the need for "corrective controls" rather than fundamental solutions.

4 • **Physical and logical placement** needs to be determined →

because it defines the boundaries, restricts lateral movement, and determines the effectiveness of both physical and digital security controls. If you don't know where the calculation is performed, you have no idea about the system's integrity

5 • ^{security} **Multiple algorithms or protocols** may be involved

↪ While combining techniques can sometimes strengthen security, it often results in increased complexity, potential vulnerabilities at interface points, and increased maintenance overhead.

Computer Security Challenges

when you want to
protect your system



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6

- **Attackers** only need to find a **single weakness** vulnerability in the system

- **Developers/administrators** need to find **all weaknesses** and try to fix them all (or mitigate the risk posed by the fact that they remain unresolved)

- It is an **asymmetric game!** *(i.e. the players do not stand on equal ground)* the knowledge of the system is important, so do not disclose so much information

- The attacker can **combine multiple weaknesses** (in the real world, start with non-tech vulnerability, humanware, then chain of tech vulnerability)

Computer Security Challenges



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- 7 • **Users and system managers tend to not see the benefits of security until a failure occurs**
(good security can effect usability: if the security is invisible, it doesn't impact the work of the users)
 - **good security is invisible**
 - **bad security is visible only after a security incident**
 - **(usually) good security does not generate revenues** *(i.e. if compared with advertisements, marketing etc.)*

Computer Security Challenges



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- 8 • Security requires **regular and constant monitoring** (i.e. security is a process and not a product) ... **security is costly!** Every single day, you will have to invest money and maintaining a proper security level
- 9 • Computer security It's often an **afterthought** to be incorporated into a system **after the design is complete** and not meanwhile (i.e. the Internet) (If you attempt to implement security only after completing a system's design, you will meet structural problems that cannot be solved. It is technically impossible to ensure an appropriate level of protection on an existing architecture, since security cannot be a later addition; rather, it must be natively integrated from the earliest stages of design)
- 10 • (Example: Two-level Authentication, too much time to login in an account than using only password, but you have more security) **Thought of as an impediment to efficient and user-friendly operation...** use protocol, to enhance security, on top of internet low protocols (after its design)
- (again) **security is a cost!**

Computer Security Terminology



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The attacker tries to minimize the cost of the attack in every possible way, so the first phase of the attack is often automated (after the initial phases, a human user steps in)

Adversary (threat agent): ^{or attacker} an entity that attacks, or is a threat to, a

system (It isn't only about an attack that is implemented, it can be also about potential attack). We need to anticipate what will happen: so we will need to consider all the entities that can be interested in attacking our system.

An attacker is an entity that wants to violate an organization's security policy. Consequently, if the policy does not define or take into consideration certain critical resources or behaviors, any resulting compromise cannot be formally classified or reported as a security breach, since technically no established rule has been violated.

- **Attack**: ^{an action intended to compromise the security of a system} ~~an assault on system security~~ that derives from an **intelligent**

threat; a deliberate attempt to ^{bypass} ~~evade~~ security services ^(Example: Evade the Auth Mechanism) and violate

the security policy of a system

(Example: can you play on Uni PCs during launch? It is defined in the security policy of the system)

Computer Security Terminology



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- **Adversary (threat agent)**: an entity that poses a **threat** to, a system
- **Attack**: an assault on system security that derives from an **intelligent threat**; a deliberate attempt **to evade security services** and **violate** the **security policy of a system**





In some cases the threat is not much “intelligent”

Example: some (not all) Denial of Service attacks
are rather simple (or stupid)

Example: Volumetric DoS: throw a lot of packets to the system to attack

or is a **threat** to, a

- **Attack**: an assault on system security that derives from an **intelligent threat**; a deliberate attempt **to evade security services** and **violate** the **security policy of a system**

Computer Security Terminology



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In cybersecurity, completely eliminating a threat or vulnerability is often impossible due to technical, operational, or financial constraints. Therefore, countermeasures must focus on mitigating risk by reducing the attack surface and minimizing the potential harm caused by an exploit.

Countermeasure: an action, device, procedure, or technique that

reduces a threat, a vulnerability, or an attack by ^{1 prevention} eliminating or

preventing it, ^{2 detect and recovery} by minimizing the harm it can cause, or ³ by discovering

and reporting it so that corrective actions can be taken

the vulnerability

Discover and Report the Vulnerability is a countermeasure (Discover and selling it to Vulnerability Broker isn't a countermeasure)



What happens if the attacker is able to exploit part of my Attack surface to compromise a specific service that is open to the external of my organisation? How much time for come back operational? This must be done every day for every risk that involves my organisation (this must be done for proper evaluating the assets that are inside my system)

Computer Security Terminology

- System: HW and SW used to provide some stuff/services of the business (can be a bunch of interconnected systems).
- Organisation: something related to Management of company and pays you money

- **Risk**: an **expectation of loss** expressed as the **probability** that a **particular** **threat** will exploit a **particular vulnerability** with a **particular harmful result** ^{damaging}

When we are in charge of the CySec of the System, our job is minimizing the risk by means of whatever you want (i.e specific measures)

For every single threat to your system, you must be able to properly classify this threat assigning a specific level of risk (cell of the risk matrix).

Example: phishing email to download from outside the organisation a ransomware (likelihood: almost certain; impact: it encrypts all data and backups and the attacker asks money; you are with a critical risk). Based on the risk, you have to find a countermeasure to reduce the impact, so it reduces the risk (example: education of the employee, in this case)

Impact	Likelihood				
	Rare	Unlikely	Possible	Likely	Almost certain
Catastrophic	moderate	moderate	high	critical	critical
Major	low	moderate	moderate	high	critical
Moderate	low	moderate	moderate	moderate	high
Minor	very low	low	moderate	moderate	moderate
Insignificant	very low	very low	low	low	moderate

So, you can reduce impact and likelihood with tech and human solutions (example: filtering to reduce likelihood of download malware and education to reduce impact)

RISK
MATRIX

In some cases, very likely, you are going to use a combination of different mitigation technics.

Computer Security Terminology



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It is Important for tech purposes because i can defend only something that is indicated in the security policy, otherwise it is impossible for me to defend different parts of the organisation, but currently the Security policy is shaped by a lot of stuff that is, for example, not technical or it is imposed from outside (example: requirements of certifications)



Security policy: a **set of rules and** ^{procedures} **practices** that specify **how a system**
or organization provides security services ^{with the aim} *(to protect sensitive and*
critical system resources)

Are you able to enforce the Security Policy? If you aren't able to enforce the Security policy with your boss, you have a problem, that typically happens. Enforcing the Security policy, will make you really unpopular inside the organisation (you will have tech and not tech problems (dealing with people))

Example: the **password policy** (i.e. strong passwords and their
expiration) of an organization is part of its **security policy**

Computer Security Terminology



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- **System resource (asset):** **data**; a **service** provided by a system; a **system capability**; ^{building (where the computation is placed)} an **item** of **system equipment**; a **facility** that houses system operations and equipment
- **Threat:** ^{If i have a vulnerable device, it is important to not expose it on the internet (i can define rules in the Firewall/Router to avoid the communication with it from the outside)} a **potential** ^{security breach} ~~for violation of security~~, ^{that occurs} ~~which exists~~ when there is a ^{situation} ~~circumstance~~, capability, action, or event that could ^{compromise system} ~~breach~~ **security** and ^{damage} **cause harm** ^(it is important to define level of impact and risk involved with these potential threats)

Computer Security Terminology



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- **Vulnerability**: a **flaw** or **weakness** in a system's **design, implementation, or operation and management** that could be **exploited** to **violate the system's security policy**

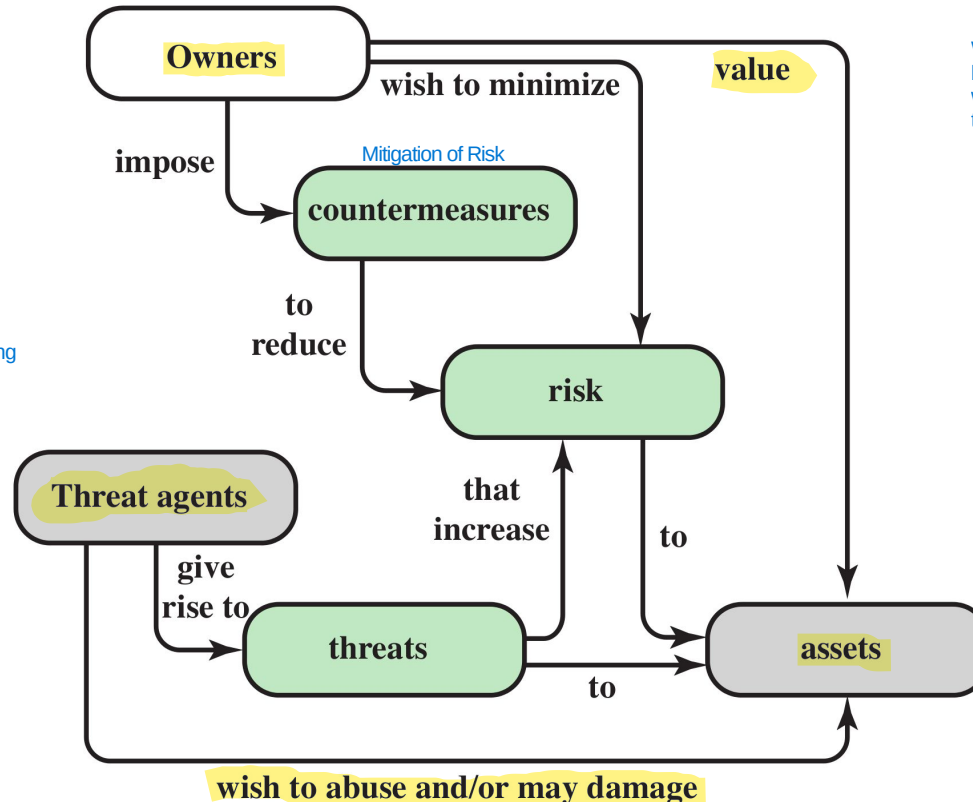
(if it isn't in the Security policy, it isn't a vulnerability (outside of the scope of the system):
in some cases, it is an error/flaw in the policy or in the system implemented)

Example: *there is a vulnerability in the **software** or the **users** are **not properly educated** to deal with email phishing*

Security Concepts and Relationship



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It seems easy to manage the risk of all assets (Asset Risk Management), but in practice to list all the threats and then being able to decide the proper countermeasures can be costly and boring

WARNING: The diagram provides a "business-level" overview (who owns what and who wants to cause harm), but it lacks the "technical" details (how the harm occurs) and

In the middle between Business and Threat Agent, there are Assets (core of the business for providing services)

Vulnerabilities, Threats and Attacks



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A system resource is considered vulnerable if it can suffer one of these three outcomes as a result of an attack

Vulnerability (of system resources):

system resource is **corrupted** when there is a (loss of integrity)

This occurs when a system resource is modified in an unauthorized or unintended manner. Integrity ensures that data is correct, complete, and unaltered.

Example: A hacker breaks into a bank's db and doesn't steal money, but changes your account balance from €100 to €1,000,000. The system is "corrupted."

system resource is **leaky** when there is a (loss of confidentiality)

This occurs when sensitive information is accessed or stolen by someone who is not authorized to do so. This is known as a "data breach."

Example: A vulnerability in a website allows an unauthorized person to access patients' medical records. The data has not been lost or altered, but it has been "leaked."

system resource is **unavailable** or very slow / **unresponsive** when there is a (loss of availability)



This occurs when authorized users cannot access a resource when they need it.

Example: A DDoS attack that floods a server with fake requests until it crashes. Or, ransomware that encrypts your files: the data is still there (its integrity and confidentiality may be intact), but you cannot use it.

Vulnerabilities, Threats and Attacks



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Formalization of Threat

Threats:

If there is a vulnerability in your code, the threat comes from an attacker who knows how to write exploit code to take advantage of that specific flaw. If there were no vulnerabilities in the system, the threat would remain outside the door, unable to act. The threat needs the vulnerability to turn into an actual attack.

capable of **exploiting vulnerabilities**

This represents the possibility that the CIA Triad could be compromised, causing economic, reputational, or operational harm to the organization.

represent a **potential security harm**

Vulnerabilities, Threats and Attacks



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(three categories)



Attacks (threats carried out):

is no more potential: is something that is happening

What matters is not the classification itself, but the consequences of the classification:

- active: i can monitor what happens and react and try to mitigate (example: attacker trying to stole an account trying different passwords, the system can, one solution, block the account avoiding login)
- passive: monitoring isn't useful, so i need to work on countermeasure (very hard to implement) (example: attacker sniff the connection and grab the wifi password encrypted without interacting with system)

active - attempt to ^{modify} ~~alter~~ **affect** the **system resources** ^{or to affect their operation.} (direct interaction with system)

passive - does **not** (directly) **affect** the **system resources** (no direct interaction with the system itself: like intercept communication)

insider or **outsider** (is it from an **internal** or **external** ^{threat} ~~thread~~?)

In the past, everything that is outside is bad and everything that is inside is good (example: LAN protocol is designed based on this). Now, the world changed a lot and most of attacks comes from inside, for example by compromission of device/applications. Now, it is used a lot the Zero-Trust Approach (everything is untrusted up to when you demonstrate that you are legitimated to do something: every time that there is an interaction with the infrastructure, you must be able to validate yourself and to demonstrate that you are legitimated)

More info about **active** and **passive** attacks in the following...

- **Attacks** (threats)
 - **active** - attempt to **alter/affect** the **system resources**
 - **passive** – does **not** (directly) **affect** the **system resources**
 - **insider** or **outsider** (is it from an **internal** or **external thread**?)

Countermeasures



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All three are very important

- Any ^{measures} means taken to deal with a security attack

○ ^{try my best to} **prevent** the attack

Define the steps for each,
before being compromised

○ **detect** the attack until it is too late

If the system is compromised, I need to

○ **recover** from attack

Countermeasures



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- **Any means** taken to deal with a security attack

- prevent

- detect

- recover

Is that **always** possible?

Countermeasures



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- **Any means** taken to deal with a security attack

- prevent

(Example: Vulnerability in the Web Server and i don't have the update to fix it (can't prevent). So, because i can't shutdown the entire Web Server and i can't do nothing to prevent the compromission, i do my best for enhancing the detection of compromission and recovery if it happens)

- detect

- recover

No! That's why detection and recovery are of main importance

Countermeasures



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- **Any means** taken to deal with a security attack
 - prevent
 - detect
 - recover

Countermeasures



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Countermeasures

-  **May introduce new vulnerabilities**
-  Such vulnerabilities may be exploited by threat agents representing a residual level of risk to the assets.
• **Residual vulnerabilities may remain**
- The **goal** is to **minimize residual level of risk** to the assets
(*that is to implement some kind of **mitigation***)

Typically, you have similar type of attack of different systems (so classify them is important to deny the attack to this category). Although the CIA triad was originally developed to define security objectives, in practice it is frequently used to classify threats based on which pillar they target.

If an attack is successful, it leads to an undesirable violation of security (Threat Consequences of the attack)

Threat Consequences

Threats are linked to CIA Triad



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4 Different classification that is useful to understand the different typical attacks

Divulgazione non autorizzata

Unauthorized disclosure is a threat to **confidentiality**

There are various types of attacks that lead to the same end result: someone sees something they shouldn't.

1 Exposure: the accidental or intentional disclosure of sensitive data in an unsecured environment.

exposure: this can be ^{intentional} **deliberate** or be the result of a human, hardware, or software **error**

Example: An employee accidentally posts an Excel file containing salary information on the company's public website, or a database server is left unsecured on the internet.

2 Interception: occurs when data is captured as it travels from point A to point B (more related to communication in a network or not)

interception: **unauthorized access to data**

Example: The classic man-in-the-middle (MitM) attack. You connect to the airport's Wi-Fi, and an attacker intercepts the data packets you send to your bank.

3 Inference: secret information is obtained by analyzing data that is not secret or by observing the system's behavior.

inference: e.g., **traffic analysis** or **use of limited access to get detailed information**

Example: I can't read the contents of your emails (they're encrypted), but I see that every morning at 9:00 a.m. you send an email to the legal department and then to the CEO. I can infer that there's a legal negotiation underway.

4 Intrusion: direct, unauthorized access to a system for the purpose of stealing data (example: get data from db).

intrusion: **unauthorized access to sensitive data**

Example: A hacker exploits a vulnerability in the web server to gain a "shell" (control of the computer) and manually copies sensitive files to their PC.

Threat Consequences



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3 Different classification that is useful to understand the different typical attacks

③



Inganno

Deception is a threat to either **system** or **data integrity**



It's an attack on identity. The system thinks it's talking to Mario Rossi, but it's actually talking to Fabio Verdi.

Example: Trojan malware impersonating good software with backdoors or other things. Another example: modify IP address to a packet to avoid filters on addresses and push malware

masquerade: e.g., **Trojan horse**; or an attempt by an unauthorized user to gain **access** to a system **by posing as an authorized user**

(example: DNS poisoning corrupts the records in a DNS resolver's cache, redirecting users from legitimate websites to fake or malicious sites)



This is a direct attack on the data. In this case, the attacker already has access (or gains it) and alters the existing information.

falsification: the **alteration** or **replacement** of valid data or the **introduction** of false data

Example: I enter new fake records (e.g., I create a fictitious "admin" user so I can log in later).

the internet is insecure and the travel of data on the internet is less secure than in the system

This is a fundamental concept for transactions and policies. It occurs when someone performs an action and then lies by claiming they didn't do it, or when the system is unable to prove that it was done.



repudiation: an entity **deceives** another by falsely **denying** **responsibility** for an act

Example: I make an online purchase, receive the merchandise, but then tell the bank, "I never authorized that transaction; give me my money back."

tricks

Threat Consequences



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3 Different classification that is useful to understand the different typical attacks



Interruzione

Disruption is a threat to **availability** or system **integrity**

1

The system simply stops existing or functioning because the physical or logical foundation is destroyed (Attack to Availability)

incapacitation: a result of physical **destruction** of or **damage** to system hardware

Example: A malicious actor cuts the fiber optic cables leading to a data center.

2

This is a "glitch" or a "poisoning" of the system. The system is still "up," but it's doing the wrong thing or behaving chaotically (Attack to system integrity)

corruption: system resources or services function in an **unintended** manner; **unauthorized modification**

Example: A hacker modifies the routing table of a router. The router is "on," but it's sending all your traffic to a dead end or a malicious server.

3

The system is working correctly, and the data is fine, but the "path" to get there is blocked or so slow that it becomes useless (Attack to Availability)

obstruction: e.g. **overload** the system or interfere with communications

Example: A DDoS (Distributed Denial of Service) attack. The server is fine, the data is safe, but 1 million fake users are knocking on the door, so the "real" users can't get in.

It isn't important to classify PRECISELY every incident. When i want to know if a system is secure or not, I need a procedure to be followed: use these 4 slides as Guidelines to assess the security of the system

The main criticism of this model (last 4 pages) is that the categories often bleed into one another. Because one attack can hit all four categories, it can feel like the classification isn't "sharp" enough to define a specific event.



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Threat Consequences

2 Different classification that is useful to understand the different typical attacks



Usurpazione

Usurpation is a threat to **system integrity** →

Misappropriation is defined as the unauthorised acquisition of control or privileges of a resource (the attacker takes possession of the resource itself), while misuse occurs when the attacker, even without having stolen ownership of the resource, manages to manipulate its behavior to force it to perform functions that are harmful to the system's security.

This is a threat to the ownership and access of a resource.



This is the "Hostile Takeover" of a resource. An attacker gains the control of a part of the system and can now use the resource as if they were the owner.

misappropriation: an entity ^{gains} **unauthorized** logical or physical

control of a system resource

Example: An attacker gains "Root" or "Administrator" access to your web server. They haven't broken it (yet), but they now "own" all the data and processing power on it.

Without being detected, by using a system in a way other than its intended purpose



The attacker doesn't necessarily "own" the whole system, but they force a specific part of it to do something it wasn't supposed to do, something that hurts your security.

misuse: causes a system component to perform a **function** or **service**

that ^{compromises the} **is detrimental to system security**

- Example: Using a legitimate company email server to send out millions of Spam messages or Phishing links. The server is doing what it was built for (sending emails), but it is being misused in a way that damages the company's reputation and security.
- Another Example: An attacker installs a Crypto-miner on your server. The server still hosts your website, but it's wasting 90% of its CPU power making money for the hacker.

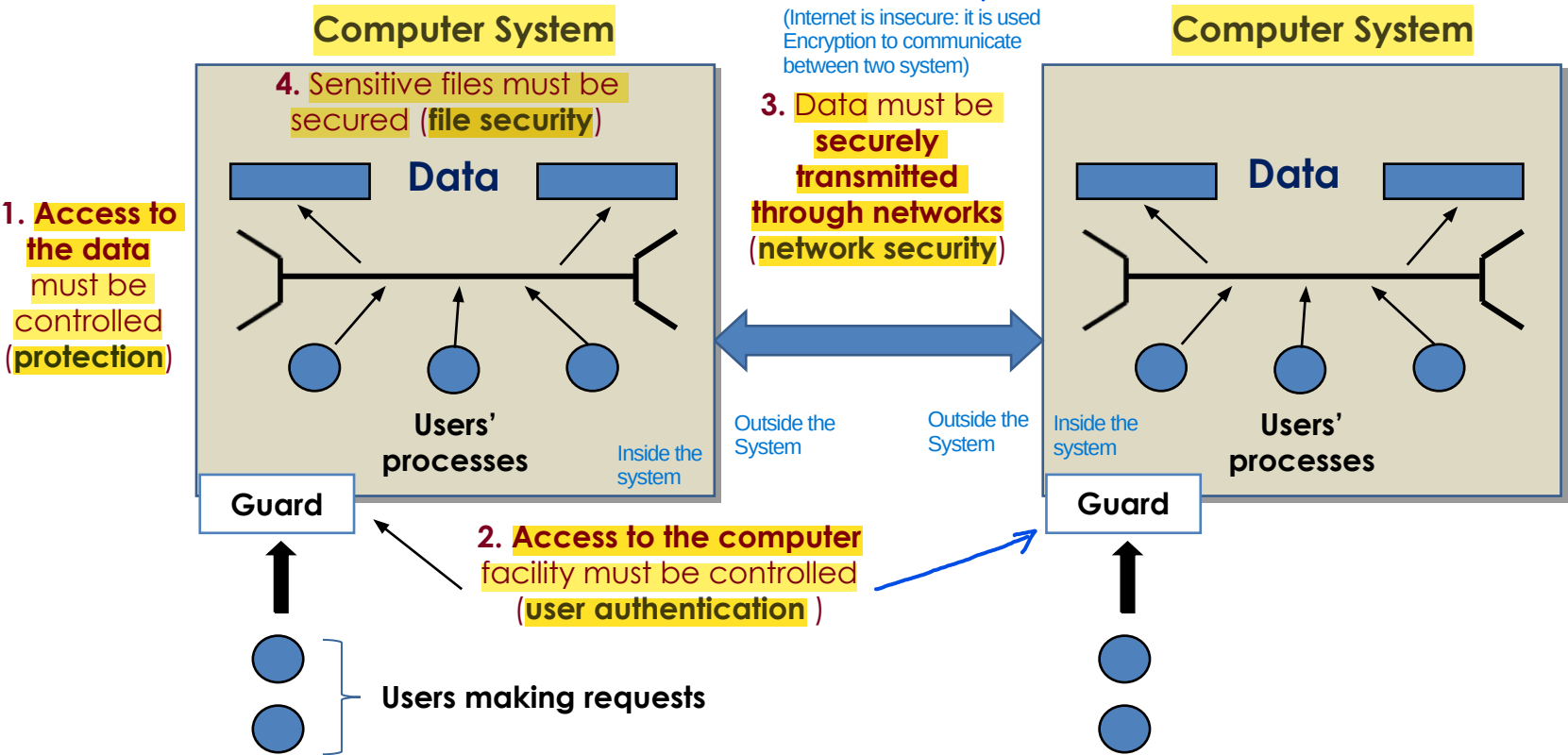
Once you have defined the Threats and their Attacks, you move from the "What can go wrong?" phase to the "What do we do about it?" phase.
In a professional security framework, this follows a specific logical flow: Risk Assessment (Probability, Impact) -> Security Policy (Prevent, Detect, Recover) -> Security Implementation.



Cybersecurity is not a single entity, but is composed of several macro-areas (Network Security, Software/File Security, Physical/Access Security). When assessing the security of a system, you must consider them all together. A chain is only as strong as its weakest link.

(Example of Attack:
Man-in-the-middle, somebody
intercepting communication,
modifying packets and
impersonating the destination of

Scope of Computer Security



The table is not so perfect because some things are obsolete/missing: so this table is good to be used as Guideline to analyse the system security in terms of CIA Triad or design properly a system. If a mechanism (part of system) can't properly react/resist to these kind of actions by the attacker (example: Data Integrity Issues), it means that you are using a System that is prone to this kind of actions

The cells contain examples of threats to a specific security property that needs to be ensured for a certain type of asset

Scope of Computer Security

Digital Forensics: It is the practice of identifying, preserving, extracting, and documenting computer evidence so that it can be used in a court of law or an internal investigation.

CIA Triad

Big issue of Data Conf and Integrity: how to know that the unauth read/modification/creation has been done? You need a proper infrastructure (track the data leaked/modified/created or possibly (report sec. incident: what data been leaked or potentially. You can't lie or be fined))

Assets of a Computer System	Availability	Confidentiality	Integrity
Hardware	Equipment is stolen or disabled, thus denying service	An unencrypted USB drive is stolen	Author of the book thinks that rarely the integrity of the hardware can be affected (not true, example of skimmers in ATMs)
Software	Programs are deleted, denying access to users	It is Software Piracy An unauthorized copy of software is made	A working program is modified to cause it to fail or to cause it to do some unintended task
Data	(Example of attack: Ramsonware) Files are deleted, denying access to users	An unauthorized read of data is performed. An analysis of statistical data reveals underlying data (User Auth and Authorization (Access Control) is important)	User Auth and Control Access is important (if the file can be modified only be his author, we don't have unauthorized modifications) Existing files are modified or new files are fabricated Given that we aren't able to verify a property, we try to avoid the problem by means of a constraint in the definition of the problem itself (Instead of constantly checking if a file is "correct," you limit who can touch it so that it cannot be incorrect: this is shifting from Detection (checking for errors) to Prevention by Design (using constraints to make errors impossible).)
Communication Lines and Networks	(Internet is not designed for Availability) Messages are destroyed or deleted. Communication lines or networks are rendered unavailable	example: same communication with server for paying will be duplicated to do the same other times Messages are read. Traffic patterns are observed reordered: if a protocol doesn't have a Sequence Number, an attacker can modify the order of the messages	Messages are modified, delayed, reordered, duplicated. False messages are fabricated if the channel isn't secure (ex: HTTP) All actions that an entity between source and destination can do with a Packet

If you simply say, "I have a loss of confidentiality", you've only identified the general problem. The specific details about the assets are what help you understand exactly what has been compromised, because they completely change depending on the context: The vulnerability the attacker exploited. The actual damage to the company. The technical countermeasure you need to implement to resolve the issue.



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Scope of Computer Security

	Availability	Confidentiality	Integrity
Hardware	Equipment is stolen or disabled, thus denying service	An unencrypted USB drive is stolen	
Software	Programs are deleted, denying access to users	An unauthorized copy of software is made	A working program is modified to cause it to fail or to cause it to do some unintended task
Data	Files are deleted, denying access to users	An unauthorized read of data is performed. An analysis of statistical data reveals underlying data	Existing files are modified or new files are fabricated
Communication Lines	Messages are destroyed or deleted. Communication lines or networks are rendered unavailable	Messages are read. Traffic patterns are observed	Messages are modified, delayed, reordered, duplicated. False messages are fabricated



Reads the content of the card (that isn't properly secured)

Example: the ATM skimmers



Integrity



A working program is modified to cause it to fail or to cause it to do some unintended task

Existing files are modified or new files are fabricated

Messages are modified, delayed, reordered, duplicated. False messages are fabricated

Scope of Computer Security



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	Availability	Confidentiality	Integrity
Hardware	Equipment is stolen or disabled, thus denying service	An unencrypted USB drive is stolen	
Software	Programs are deleted, denying access to users	Or <u>encrypted!</u>	
Data	Files are deleted, denying access to users		
Communication Lines	Messages are destroyed or deleted. Communication lines or networks are rendered unavailable	Messages are read. Traffic patterns are observed	Messages are modified, delayed, reordered, duplicated. False messages are fabricated

Sco

Hardware

Software

Data

Communication

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grity

program is
use it to fail or
to do some
ed taske modified or
fabricatede modified,
eordered,
lse messages
icated

Your personal files are encrypted!



Private key will be destroyed on
10/20/2013
12:37 PM

Time left
72 : 34 : 50

Your important files **encryption** produced on this computer: photos, videos, documents, etc. [Here](#) is a complete list of encrypted files, and you can personally verify this.

Encryption was produced using a **unique** public key [RSA-2048](#) generated for this computer. To decrypt the files you need to obtain the **private key**.

The **single copy** of the private key, which will allow you to decrypt the files, located on a secret server on the Internet; the server will **destroy** the key after a time specified in this window. After that, **nobody and never will be able** to restore files...

To obtain the private key for this computer, which will automatically decrypt files, you need to pay **300 USD / 300 EUR** / similar amount in another currency.

Click «Next» to select the method of payment.

Any attempt to remove or damage this software will lead to the immediate destruction of the private key by server.

[Next >>](#)

Your personal files are encrypted!

Your important files **encryption** produced on this computer: photos, videos, documents, etc. [Here](#) is a complete list of encrypted files, and you can personally verify this.

Encryption was produced using a **unique** public key [RSA-2048](#) generated for this computer. To decrypt the files you need to obtain the **private key**.

The **single copy** of the private key, which will allow you to decrypt the files, located on a secret server on the Internet; the server will **destroy** the key after a time specified in this window. After that, **nobody and never will be able** to restore files...

crypt files, you

Based on Zero-Days (discovered but not reported to Microsoft, so stolen by other company)

Case Study: WannaCry

Private

immediate

Time left

72 : 34 : 50

Next >>

program is
use it to fail or
to do some
ed task

e modified or
fabricated

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Hardware

Software

Data

Communication

Scope of Computer Security



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	Availability	Confidentiality	Integrity
Hardware	Equipment is stolen or disabled, thus denying service	An unencrypted USB drive is stolen	
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Communication Lines	Messages are destroyed or deleted. Communication lines or networks are rendered unavailable	Messages are read. Traffic patterns are observed	Messages are modified, delayed, reordered, duplicated. False messages are fabricated

Passive and Active Attacks

Kind of mitigation is different from
Passive (cannot perform Reactive Security) to Active (Reactive Security)



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- **Passive attacks** attempt to **learn** or make use of information from the system **but do not affect system resources** (Example: sniff packets during communication)

(no modification to)

Disclosure of Message Contents: The attacker intercepts the communication and reads the plaintext.

Example: The attacker reads the message "Hi, see you at 3:00 p.m." sent by a chat user. This constitutes a direct breach of data confidentiality.

Traffic Analysis: Even if the messages are encrypted (so the attacker cannot read their content), the attacker observes the data flow. They see who is talking to whom, the frequency of messages, their size, and connection times. Example in your system: The attacker notices that a user's IP address suddenly sends a burst of encrypted packets to the company server at exactly every hour. Even if they don't know what's written, they suspect it's an automatic backup or a critical data exchange.

Eavesdropping is the unauthorized interception of private communication. In a digital network, this usually means capturing "packets" of data as they travel from Point A to Point B. (to avoid that they get sensitive information, use encryption)

example: eavesdropping/monitoring of transmissions

One is a Passive Attack (illegal/unauthorized), while the other is a Security mechanism (legal/authorized).

- **difficult to detect** because you have small or no evidence that they are doing Passive Attacks (because there aren't any type of modifications to system resources)

- **emphasis is on prevention rather than detection** There is no easy mitigation of it

two main types (of passive attacks) **(message contents, traffic analysis)**

Passive and Active Attacks



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The transmission is intercepted

- **Passive attacks** attempt to intercept data without affecting the system **but do not affect system resources**
 - **example:** eavesdropping/monitoring of transmissions
 - **difficult to detect**
 - emphasis is on **prevention** rather than detection
 - **two** main types (**message contents**, **traffic analysis**)

Passive and Active Attacks



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- **Passive attacks** attempt to **learn** or make use of information from the system **but do not affect system resources**
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 - emphasis is on **prevention** rather than detection
 - **two** main types (**message contents**, traffic **analysis**)

Passive and Active Attacks



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Content can be in clear or encrypted (it depends on the channel encryption)

- **Passive attacks** attempt to intercept data from a system **but do not affect** system
 - **example:** eavesdropping
 - **difficult to detect**
 - emphasis is on **prevention** rather than detection
 - **two** main types (**message contents**, traffic **analysis**)

This happens when the message
is transmitted “in clear”

(not encrypted) message text
encrypted: cypher text



Even when the messages are encrypted
it is possible to perform some analysis

For example: content size, frequency...

- **difficult to detect**
- emphasis is on **prevention** rather than detection
- **two** main types (**message contents**, **traffic analysis**)

It is important to be able to understand the different categories, so when you try to analyse the security of the system (example: system that you are designing/developing), it will be easier for you to try to follow these approach (an example is the table seen) and to ask to yourself if the system is prone to these type of attacks



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Passive and Active Attacks

- **Active attacks** involve **modification** of the data stream (or the attacked system)

If there is modification/interaction with the system, it is an active attack
If there isn't, it is a passive attack

- the goal is to **detect** them and to **recover**

4 categories

○ four main types:

of active attacks

- **masquerade**
- **replay**
- **modification of messages**
- **denial of service**

Typically, these attacks occurs on the Internet because it is easier when there is a network than inside a system (more secure than internet and much harder)

- IDS (Intrusion Detection System): This is monitoring software whose primary purpose is to identify anomalous, suspicious, or known malicious activity within a system or network. The IDS operates in passive mode: once an anomaly is detected, it generates an alert for system administrators, allowing them to verify whether it is legitimate behavior (a false positive) or to initiate recovery procedures.

- IPS (Intrusion Prevention System): This represents the active and reactive evolution of the IDS. The IPS does not simply detect the attack, but intervenes in real time to block it before it can compromise the system (for example, by terminating the malicious network connection or blocking the sender's IP address).

Typical Attack in the real world:
- Passive to gather information without being spotted
- Active to perform it using info gathered before

Passive



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One **entity** pretends to be a
different entity

Example: a *user* or a *device*

- **Active attacks**

attacked

or the

- the **goal** is to **steal** them and to **recover**
- four main types:

- **masquerade**
- **replay**
- **modification of messages**
- **denial of service**

Passive and Active

- **Active attacks** involve an attacker (or attackers) interacting with the attacked system)
 - the **goal** is to compromise the system
 - four main types

Direct Replay: no modifications

Attacker can modify the message if it isn't properly encrypted

Passive capture of a data unit and its subsequent **retransmission** to produce an **unauthorized effect**:

Man-In-The-Middle (MITM) attack

Example: "Open sesame"

Couple of words without meaning but i understand the semantic (opens the door)

In some type of attacks, you can use masquerade+replay (used to bypass both Authentication and Access Control.)

- **masquerade**
- **replay**
- **modification of messages**
- **denial of service**

"it is the subsequent retransmission" to define that it is an Active Attack

Passive and Active Attacks



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- **Active attacks**

attacked

- the s

- four main ty

- masquer

- replay

- **modification of messages**

Modify a part of the communication

- denial of service

I think that it is obvious

Example: *to change the IBAN
code in a bank transfer*

am (or the

Passive and Active Attacks



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- **Active attacks**

attacked system

- the **goal**
- four main

- masquerade
- replay
- modification of messages
- **denial of service**

An **interruption** in an authorized user's access to a computer network, typically one caused with malicious intent

Example: the *Mirai* botnet

is malware that turns networked devices running Linux into remotely controlled bots that can be used as part of a botnet in large-scale network attacks. It primarily targets online consumer devices such as IP cameras and home routers.

Even if they are important, It is very difficult/impossible to be able to design a product that satisfies all design principles that are listed here. Not all the design principles have same importance: some of them are more important than others and it depends on your setup (a Bank has a Threat Model different from the others, for example)

Security Design Principles

IMPORTANT: A good blueprint/guideline to how to design a proper cybersecurity aware system or evaluate a system



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1

Another formulation of KISS principle

Economy of mechanism: the design of security ^{mechanisms} ~~measures~~ should be as simple as possible (i.e. **simpler** to implement and to verify, **fewer vulnerabilities**)

2

• **Fail-safe default:** access decisions should be based on **permissions** rather than exclusion (i.e., **the default is lack of access**)

It is preferred to automatically restrict the permissions and only by human intervention (admin), we will decide case by case who is authorized to enter in the system

3

Implementing Complete mediation is costly (in terms of design, interaction between the different parts, etc..)

• **Complete mediation:** every access should be ^{verified based on} ~~checked against~~ the **Access Control system** (see Chapter 4)

Authorization: what resources, the user authenticated, can access and with which permissions.

Security Design Principles



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- 4 • **Open design:** the design^{of a security mechanism} should be **open rather than secret** (e.g.,

encryption algorithms)^{only the private key must be secret} (Shannon Reformulation)

No single person or process should have complete control over critical actions. To access a protected resource or complete a high-risk task, multiple keys or independent authorizations must be required.

Separation of privileges: **multiple privileges** should be required to

achieve access to a restricted resource (or to complete some tasks)

Least privilege: every user (or process)^{software} should operate **using the least**^{minimum}

set of privileges necessary to perform a task (e.g., the sysadmin must

not surf the Web using the administrator user)

otherwise, a single compromise, in a single part of the system, is able to get a lot of credentials, to compromise other parts of the system, etc..

5

Strongly
Linked with

6

It is the opposite of usability (when I use the PC I want all the permissions to avoid slowing my operations)

Security Design Principles



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(example: reduce the amount of accounts with same password because with one data breach, you are compromised on all accounts). When different users or programs share a mechanism (like a password, a database, or a piece of memory), that mechanism becomes a Single Point of Failure. When designing a system, it is important to minimize the number of functions, communication channels, or resources shared among different users or programs. If two distinct entities rely on the exact same mechanism to function, that mechanism becomes a major vulnerability for the security of the entire system.

7 • **Least common mechanism**: a design should minimize the **functions** or resources

shared by different users/entities (e.g., *sharing state among different*

software programs)

If you create different environments that are divided by them, you are implementing Least Common Mechanism. If you have something that is overlapping, it is easier to get a compromise that is not confined only to a single software (because there is interaction between different part of the software) (LCM not implemented).

8 • **Psychological acceptability**: the security mechanisms should not

~~unduly~~ ^{excessively/unnecessarily} **interfere** with the work of users (i.e. **user's acceptance of**

security mechanisms)

When we try to push for an increase of Security level, everytime you should consider carefully what is the psychological reaction of the users: if the psychological reaction of the users is something that is against the acceptability of enforcing this specific mechanism, we are doing something wrong:

1) Why are they reacting like that?

2) Investigating if there is a better way for doing things (most of the times, there are but costly and not so easy for admin, so we prefer to push the problem to the user instead of solving the problem as system administrator)

Full separation is not possible, because i also need inter-operability between applications (i need to have exceptions)

Security Design Principles



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When you design a system, you shouldn't aim for Maximum Isolation. Instead, you should aim for Optimal Isolation. You identify the most critical resources and isolate those, while leaving non-critical paths more open to keep the system fast (too much Isolation lowers system performance). Not all kinds of isolation are the same: there are different type of isolation (for example, is better the physical isolation than logical, but the physical one is costier than logical one) and different type of software/hardware isolation

Isolation:

A ○ **public access**^{systems} should be isolated from critical resources^{to prevent disclosure or tampering} (i.e., no

connection between public and critical information)

Example: (Air Gapping) If a component is exposed to the public (such as a web server), it must not have a "direct connection" to critical resources (such as the payment database or system files).

B ○ **users**^{processes and} **files** should be isolated from one another (except when **desired**) (example: same computer, different users registered in the PC, so we have logical isolation of files: users are separated)

C ○ the **security mechanism** should be isolated (i.e., preventing
access to those mechanisms)

as much as possible, otherwise it will possible for the attacker to compromise the security mechanism and after that to escalate on the whole system (get super privilege on the system)

With Modularity and Isolation, we enter the debate about The Monolithic Kernel vs. The Microkernel:

In a monolithic system (like Linux, Windows, or macOS), almost all core services (drivers, file systems, and the Security Module) run in the same "privileged" memory space (Kernel Space): we have more performance but less Isolation and Modularity.

A Microkernel (like QNX or L4) takes the opposite approach. It only keeps the absolute "bare essentials" in the kernel. Everything else (drivers, file systems, security) runs as a separate, isolated Module.



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Security Design Principles

Idea behind: redesign the system in a way that every single modification/interaction to the system is mediated by another piece of software that is in charge of doing that (solves problems about concurrency and boost accountability (responsibility on actions) in the system). Encapsulation hides the complexity and internal structure, and present only a controlled, clean interface to the outside world. If an attacker cannot see how your internal data structures are built, how your servers are organized, or how the inner workings of your code function, they won't know where to attack. Encapsulation creates an opaque barrier that protects the integrity and confidentiality of what is inside.

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Encapsulation: similar to **object-oriented programming concepts** (i.e.,

hide internal structures)

→ You should never be able to modify directly something from a part of the system (example: Data Structure, that can be also a File System that is shared inside a network, and there are a different nodes that can, at the same time, concurrently, modify its shared resource, you have a problem: because there is no entity inside the system that is in charge of the management of this shared resource)

Idea: if i create a system in which the security functions are meld together with the other functions of the system, i have a problem because they are not properly separated (if there is modularity, it is easier to protect the security stuff of the system)

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Modularity: development of security functions as **separate, protected**

modules and use of a **modular architecture** (*for the mechanism*

design and implementation)

→ It is not easy to do it (implementation is hard to do). For example, the OS gives us the security module that is incorporated inside the OS: this goes against Modularity, but this is the best way of doing it because although i need to estrapolate the security module from the OS and put it in a separate part of the kernel. If you prioritize Modularity, the system becomes slow and users will hate it (Psychological Acceptability). If you prioritize Integration, the system is fast but one "Kernel Exploit" (like the SMB bug in WannaCry) can bypass every security check at once.

It is a good idea to centralize the Security Module instead of Replicate them in each File System

The difference between bad and good security is on the properly understanding of the Thread Model and not applying Security design principle that are useless and costly in situation in which they aren't able to mitigate the problem itself. If you apply a high-cost security principle to a low-risk asset, you aren't being "more secure", you are being inefficient.



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Security Design Principles

Layering can be really good if it is able to enhance your security when considering the proper Threat Model (if you aren't, layering is only a problem of usability). Example: (online banking) if you consider, in the Threat Model, the compromise of the browser/user device, all the layering is totally useless because the browser is the single piece of software that is in charge of getting all of your credentials and to transfer all these credentials to the backend

Idea behind this approach: risk reduction by heterogeneity. Instead of having a single line of defense, is better to have multiple lines of defense

also called

Layering (defense in depth): use of **multiple, overlapping** protection

approaches (e.g., multiple firewalls based on different technologies

and approaches) Each layer is implemented in a different way (different technologies, manufactures, etc.). Example: different type of Firewall or different type of Authentications

Minimo stupore

Least astonishment: a program or interface should always respond in

causes the user as little surprise as possible

a way that ~~is least likely to astonish a user~~ (e.g., an error window that

belong to what running program?)

If the user can be misled on a window request, the security consequences can be terrible. For example, a window that asks to confirm the password, how to know if it is a legitimate one or another application that is trying to impersonate?

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Related to
Management
and Technical

13

Related to Psychology

Security Mechanism

It is fundamental to create procedures before being involved in an attack (a document, well written and structured, that must be followed when something against the security policy happens. Example: what to do if network is compromised?)



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Every time you take a decision consider carefully your attack surface

- It is (or it should be) **designed to:**



Goal: Actively prevent the breach from happening (Before the attack).

prevent attackers from violating security policy



Goal: To immediately detect if something is going wrong or if the security policy has been violated (During the attack).

detect attackers' violation of security policy



Goal: To react quickly to minimize damage while the attack is still going on (During the attack).

response to **mitigate** attack (Mitigation)



Goal: Ensure business continuity. If an attack is successful, the system must be designed to recover on its own and continue providing service (After the attack).

recover, continue to function **correctly** even if **attack succeeds**

- No single mechanism is able to support all services:
 - **Example:** authentication, authorization, availability, confidentiality, integrity, non-repudiation

Attack Surface



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- The **reachable** and **exploitable vulnerabilities** in a system:

Examples

- services listening on the network
- services that are not protected by a firewall
- software that processes incoming data (i.e. e-mails, web pages, office documents, pdf, whatsapp messages...)
- an employee (or a subcontractor) with access to sensitive information

Attack Surface



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- The **reachable** and **exploitable vulnerabilities** in a system:

- services **listening on the network**

every time i have a socket listening on the network

“Open ports”: running processes

using network sockets

(piece of software with a socket open and so the ability to perform communication)

information



A “**firewall**” is a software or hardware tool used to **restrict the network access to a system**

abilities in a system:

- **services** listening on the network
- **services** that are **not protected by a firewall**
- **software** that **processes incoming data** (i.e. e-mails, web pages, office documents, pdf, whatsapp messages...)
- an **employee** (or a **subcontractor**) with **access to sensitive information**

Firewall: network security hardware or software designed to filter traffic based on a set of predefined rules.

- Standard Inspection (Packet Filtering): Traditionally, a firewall performs superficial checks by analyzing only the header of each individual packet (for example, verifying the source/destination IP addresses and TCP/UDP ports).
- The Limitation of Spoofing: It is crucial to remember that there is no guarantee of the header's integrity, as the information within it can be easily forged by an attacker using techniques such as IP spoofing.

- Deep Packet Inspection (DPI) and the Limits of Encryption: Modern firewalls are capable of performing deep inspection, analyzing not only the header but also the packet's payload in search of malware or anomalies. However, this in-depth analysis becomes impossible in the presence of end-to-end encryption (E2EE), since the payload's content is completely unreadable and inaccessible to the firewall itself.



Its goal is to ^{allow/grant} permit authorized
access and to deny unauthorized
(i.e., malicious) attempts

abilities in a system:

- services listening on network
- services that are not protected by a firewall
- software that processes incoming data (i.e. e-mails, web pages, office documents, pdf, whatsapp messages...)
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Attack Surface



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- The **reachable** and **exploitable** vulnerabilities in a system:
 - **services** listening on the network
 - **services** that are **not protected by a firewall**
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Attack Surface



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... but also **Application**
Programming Interfaces (APIs),
SQL queries, web forms etc..

abilities in a system:

services that are not protected by a firewall

- **software** that **processes incoming data** (i.e. e-mails, web pages, office documents, pdf, whatsapp messages...)
- an **employee** (or a **subcontractor**) with **access to sensitive information**



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Network Scanning



NMAP

Exposed attack surface

What is it?

Check it out!

T1

Attack Surface: categories

Is difficult to assess if a software is local or not (is local when it doesn't send data on the internet): example, update checkers



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• Three main categories^{of the Attack Surface}

- 1 ○ **network** attack surface (i.e. **network vulnerability**)
refers to
- 2 ○ **software** attack surface (i.e. **software vulnerability**)
refers to
- 3 ○ **human** attack surface (i.e. **social engineering**)
refers to vulnerabilities like human error, and trusted insiders

Network vs Software Attack Surface: The Role of Exposition
The core difference lies in the level of exposition (how accessible a component is to an attacker):
- Network Attack Surface focuses on how an attacker can reach the system. If a component is connected to a network, its exposure changes drastically depending on whether that network is public (Internet) or private (LAN).
- Software Attack Surface focuses on what code or service can be exploited. This surface is divided based on its accessibility:
 > Remote Exposition: The software is actively "listening" on a network port (e.g., a Web Server or an open API). It is exposed to remote attacks from anywhere outside the host.
 > Local Exposition: The software is "isolated" from the network and does not open network ports. It can only be interacted with locally by processes or users who are already authenticated inside the system.

• Attack surface analysis

- it is a security technique for evaluating **assessing the scale and severity of threats** portata (scala) gravità minacce that can target the organisation (i.e. **to decide how to**

allocate the available resources)... **it is not easy**...

Attack surface analysis is fundamentally a risk management exercise (not a pure technical one). Identifying the most vulnerable points in a system is essential for the strategic allocation of security resources. However, accurately identifying these high-risk areas remains extremely complex.

Attack Trees

There are a lot of approaches that can be used to do attack surface analysis, but it is more important to understand what are the concepts that are baseline of these approaches



The hard part of this approach is to list ALL the potential vulnerabilities and their paths to be followed by the attacker

We use a plenty of Attack trees to analyse a system

- **Attack trees** are often used to perform **attack surface analysis**

- An **attack tree** is a **branching, hierarchical data structure** that

represents a set of **potential vulnerabilities**

techniques for exploiting security

An Attack Tree is a conceptual exercise designed to identify potential vulnerabilities and model the specific paths an adversary might follow to compromise a system. By analyzing these scenarios in advance, security engineers can anticipate attacker behavior. It is important to note that a single vulnerability or security objective can often be exploited through multiple alternative paths, each representing a different chain of malicious actions.

- **Objective:** to effectively **exploit** the info available on **attack patterns**

use in our favour the

standard

(i.e. *the methods used to find errors or problems in the systems*)

the attackers

in order to apply them to your system.

- **Attack trees** can be used by the **security analysts** to **guide design and**

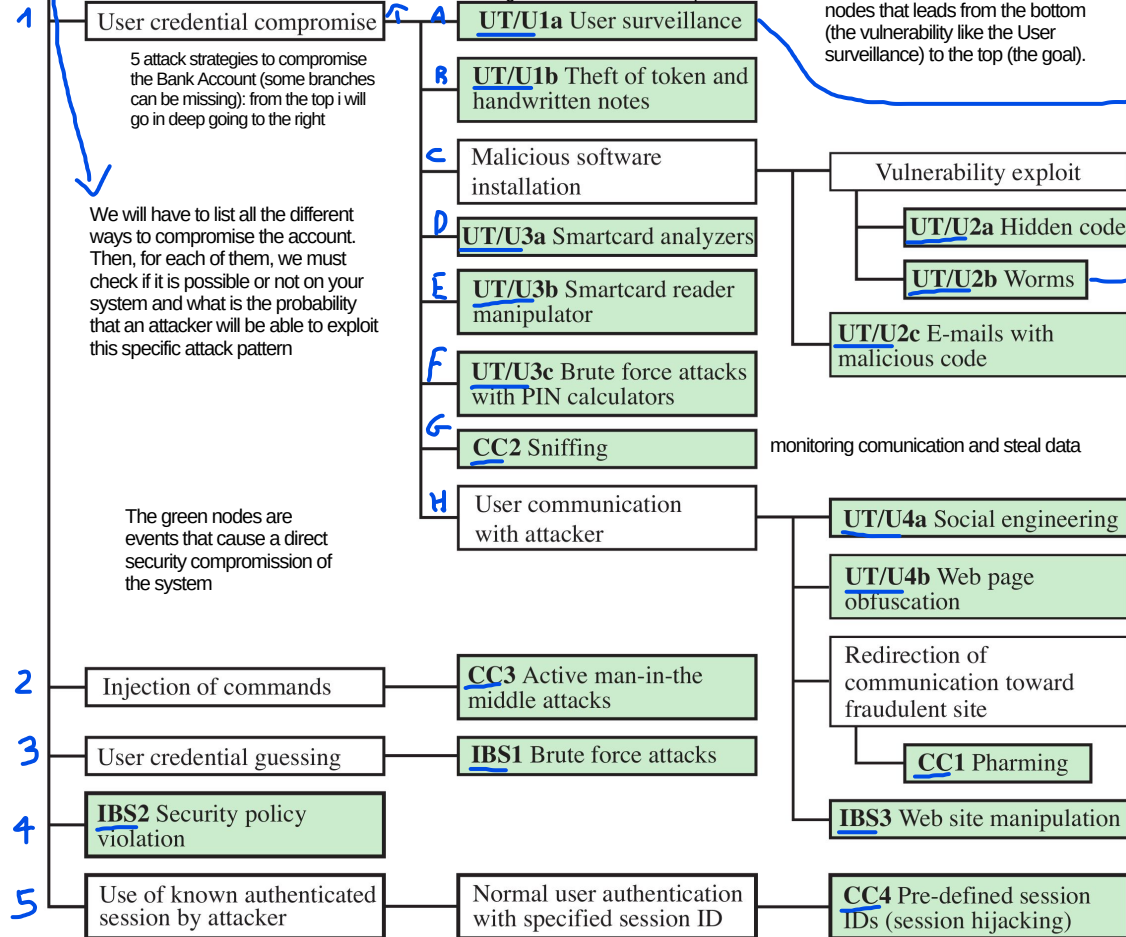
strengthen countermeasures

By annotating an attack tree with metrics such as the probability of a path being followed, we can conduct a comprehensive qualitative or quantitative risk assessment. This approach transforms the tree into a visual landscape of system risk, highlighting the paths an adversary is most likely to exploit. Consequently, security investments can be strategically directed toward reinforcing the highest-probability branches, ensuring an efficient allocation of resources to maximize overall risk

This is the Goal of the Attacker

Bank Account Compromise

what we do to achieve the subgoal "User Credential Compromise"?



Once the tree is finished, the "Path" is simply any sequence of nodes that leads from the bottom (the vulnerability like the User surveillance) to the top (the goal).

Assign Attributes to the Paths

To make the tree useful for "allocating resources," you assign values to each leaf.

- Cost: How much money does the attacker need?
- Skill Level: Is this a "Script Kiddie" attack or a "Nation-State" level attack?
- Probability: How likely is this specific vulnerability to be found?

involves monitoring, recording, or intercepting a user's digital activities (such as keystrokes, camera feeds, or network traffic) to steal data or monitor behavior (from remote on the computer)

self-replicating malware that spread across networks without human intervention, exploiting security vulnerabilities to steal data, install backdoors, or launch DDoS attacks

- Guessing is a trial-and-error approach. The attacker does not exploit a "hole" in the code; instead, they exploit the predictability of the secret or the weakness of the user's choice. It isn't a bug in the software; it's the low entropy (simplicity) of the password. (Example: Brute-force)
- Compromise (often referred to as Exploiting) is a technical circumvention. The attacker finds a way to "break" the logic of the system to get inside without ever needing to know the password or secret.

Sometimes, "Compromise" is used as a general term to say a system is no longer secure (e.g., "The server is compromised"). However, when comparing it to "Guessing," it specifically refers to exploiting a technical vulnerability rather than just hitting the right password by luck or persistence.

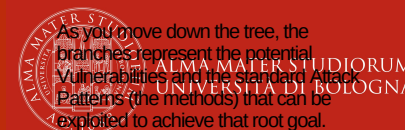
An Attack Tree is a conceptual diagram used in cybersecurity to visualize and analyze the different paths an attacker could take to achieve a specific goal. Think of it as a "threat blueprint" that helps security professionals think like a hacker.

The tree is organized hierarchically:

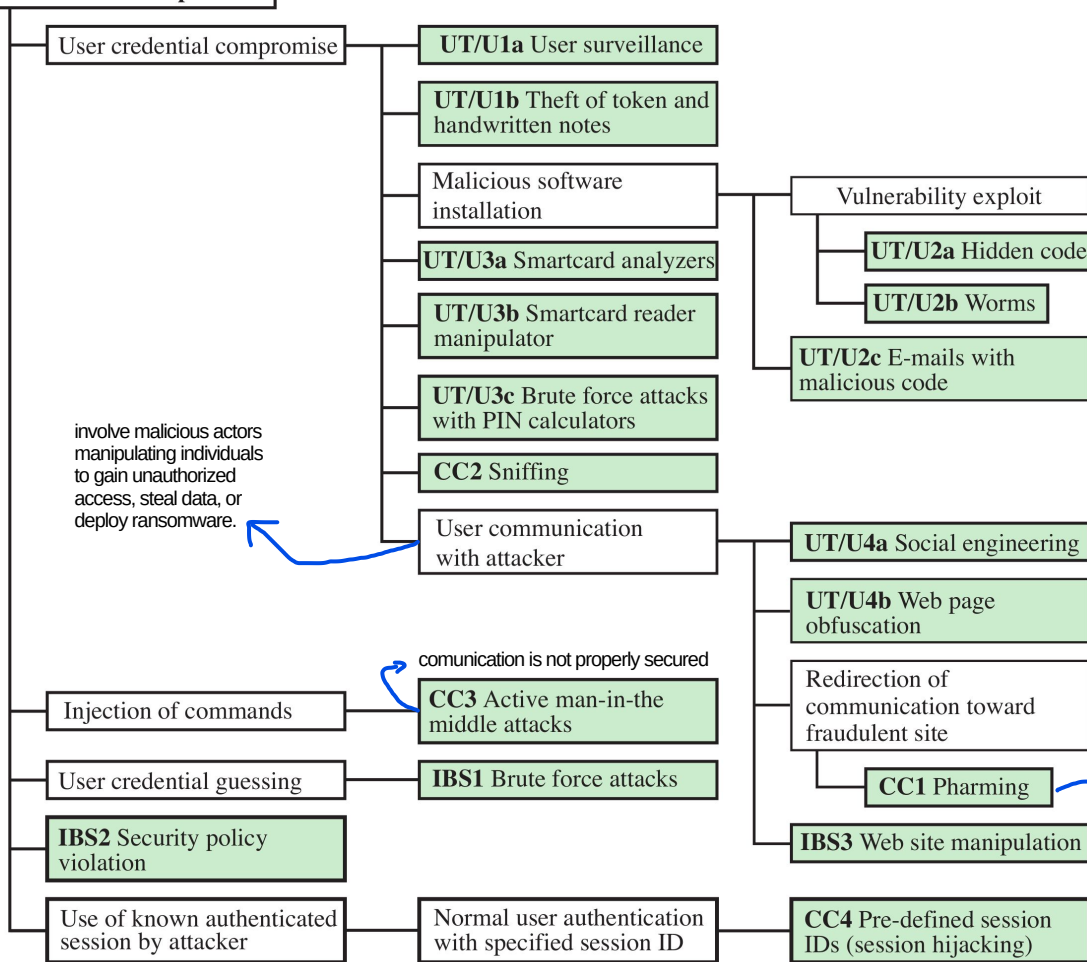
- Root Node (The Goal): This is the ultimate objective of the attacker (e.g., "Steal administrator credentials" or "Shut down the power grid").
- Leaves/Branches (The Methods): These represent the different actions or vulnerabilities that lead to the goal.

White nodes indicate an attack pattern with different specific type of attack

As you move down the tree, the branches represent the potential vulnerabilities and the standard Attack Patterns (the methods) that can be exploited to achieve that root goal.



Bank Account Compromise



The goal is to compromise an online bank account

example: typosquatting, is a form of cybercrime where attackers register domain names similar to legitimate, popular websites, preying on user typos

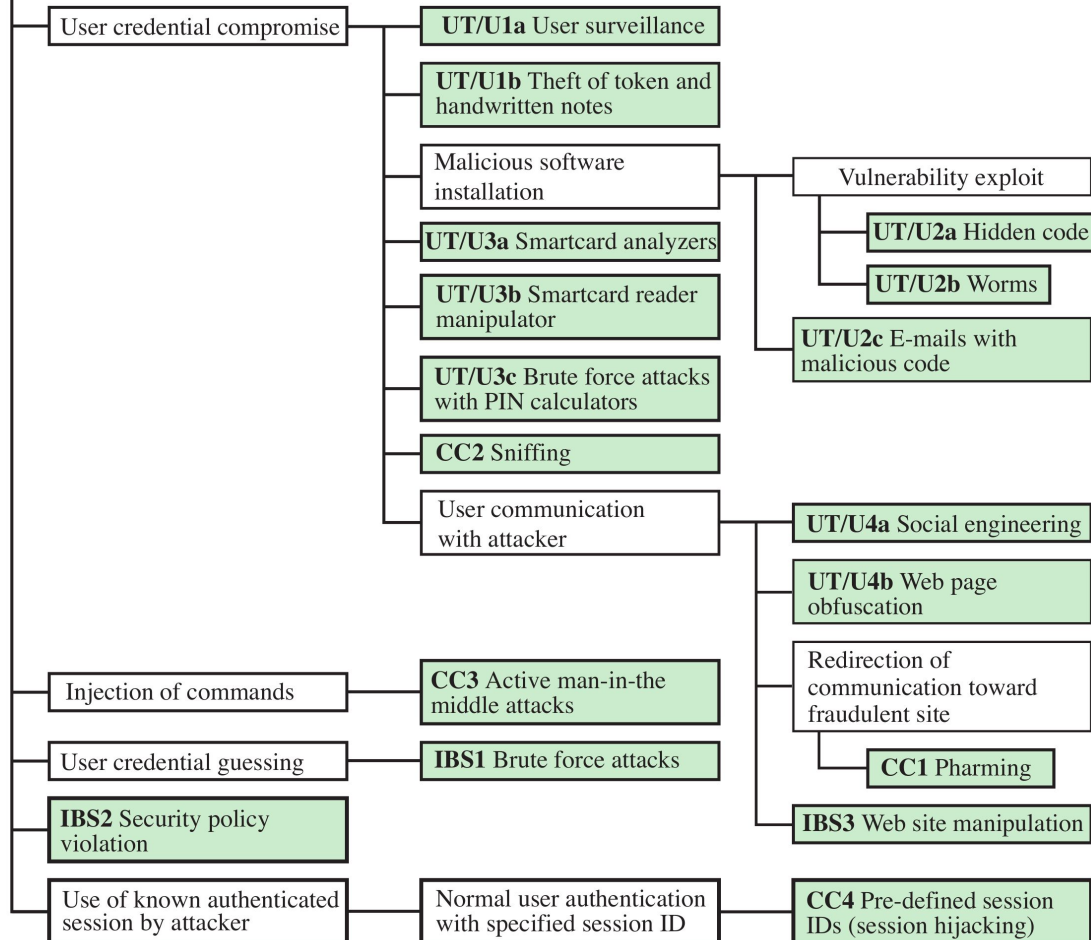
Pharming is a sophisticated cyberattack that redirects users from legitimate websites to fraudulent, attacker-controlled sites, even if the correct URL is typed. Unlike phishing, it often requires no user interaction after initial malware infection, making it highly deceptive. It steals sensitive data like banking credentials.

a part of the system can be poisoned



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Bank Account Compromise



The goal is to compromise
an online bank account

This can be done in many
different ways



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Bank Account Compromise

User credential compromise

UT/U1a User surveillance

UT/U1b Theft of token and handwritten notes

Malicious software installation

UT/U3a Smartcard analyzers

UT/U3b Smartcard reader manipulator

UT/U3c Brute force attacks with PIN calculators

UT/U3d Sniffing

UT/U3e Communication hijacker

Vulnerability exploit

UT/U2a Hidden code

UT/U2b Worms

UT/U2c E-mails with malicious code

UT/U4a Social engineering

For example:
**compromising the
credentials**

Injection of

User creden

IBS2 Security violation

Use of known authenticated session by attacker

with specified session ID

CCITT defined session IDs (session hijacking)

The goal is to compromise
an online bank account

This can be done in many
different ways



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Bank Account Compromise

User credential compromise

UT/U1a User surveillance

UT/U1b Theft of token and handwritten notes

or **guessing** them
(i.e., weak passwords)

Brute Forcing them

It is not always about complexity

Communication
Attacker

UT/U4a Social engineering

UT/U4b Web page obfuscation

Redirection of communication toward fraudulent site

CC1 Pharming

IBS3 Web site manipulation

Injection of command

CC3 Active man-in-the middle attacks

User credential guessing

IBS1 Brute force attacks

IBS2 Security policy violation

Use of known authenticated session by attacker

Normal user authentication with specified session ID

CC4 Pre-defined session IDs (session hijacking)

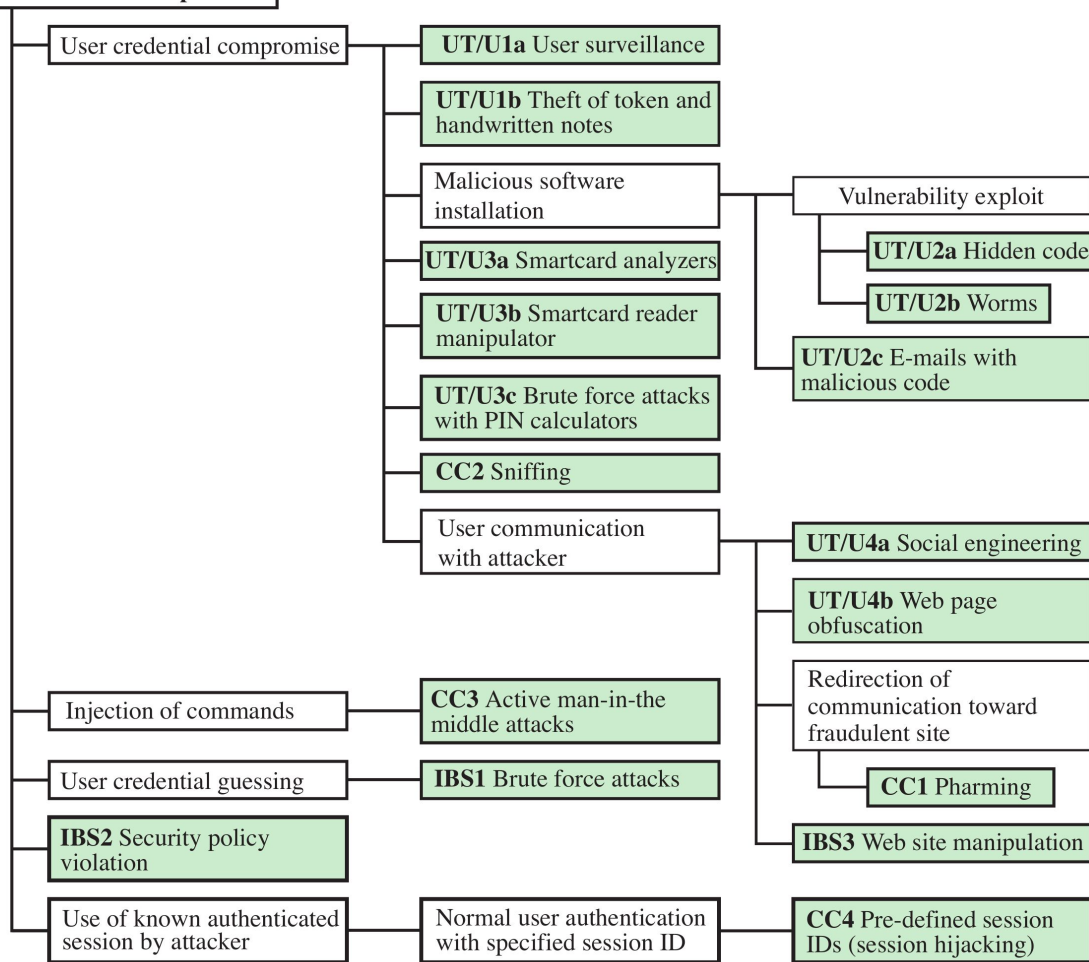
The goal is to compromise an online bank account

This can be done in many different ways



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Bank Account Compromise



Limitation of Attack Trees Approach

1) Being able to be qualitative or quantitative: to be quantitative you need data to assess the probability of each attack (without them, is a qualitative approach and is less accurate) and to define which are the most probabilistic attacks

You cannot prevent Zero days (at most, minimum prevention) because we don't have data about them (by definition of 0-days). The focus is on preventing the all that is not a 0-day



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Attributions and Notes



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- Most of the slides are from: “**Computer Security: Principles and Practice**”, 4th global edition, W. Stallings and Lawrie Brown
- Some others are from: Dr. **Mehmet H. Gunes** (Department of Computer Science & Engineering - University of Nevada, Reno)
- Some others are from: **Mario Cagalj**, Ph.D. (Faculty of Electrical Engineering, Mechanical Engineering and Naval Architecture (FESB), University of Split)
- Some others are from: Prof. **Hossein Saiedian**, University of Kansas
- The “risk matrix” is from this [blog](#)
- I wish to **thank all of them**, **any errors that remain are my sole responsibility**